



200 BC to now

The Indians wrote their numbers on palm leaves with ink, using a flowing style that made the numbers curly. The symbols for 2 and 3 were groups of lines at first, but the lines joined up when people wrote them quickly:



From this ...



to this ...



... to this.

NOTHING comes to Europe

BAGHDAD 800 AD

Indian numbers and zero spread to Baghdad, which was the centre of the newly founded Muslim empire. A man called Al Khwarizmi wrote books about maths and helped spread Indian numbers and zero to the rest of the world. The words "arithmetic" and "algorithm" come from his name, and the word "algebra" comes from his book *Ilm al-jabr wa'l muqabalab*.

We sometimes call modern numbers *Arabic*, because they spread to Europe through the Arab world

INDIA

200 BC to 600 AD
Mathematicians in India were using separate symbols for 1 to 9 as early as 300 BC. By 600 AD they had invented a place system and zero.

BAGHDAD

INDIA

The Muslim empire spread across Africa, taking zero with it.

Merchants travelling by camel train or boat took the Indian number system west.